CHAPTER 23

LOSS

The day before our last ODI in Sri Lanka, I get a call from Daniella. We have been expecting a baby. The last time we had spoken, she'd had a 12-week scan and everything was OK. We are planning on going to the Maldives when the tour is over – a belated honeymoon and a last moment together before our worlds change. When the phone rings in the early morning, while I'm still asleep, I'm immediately filled with that knowing sixth sense that can prelude bad news. Intuitively, only seconds between the unconscious mind and the waking one, I just know that on the other side of the phone call is loss. When I pick up, her tone is urgent and sad. She went to have another scan privately, she says, because she'd heard that they would be able to tell the sex of the baby and she couldn't wait until she flew. When they checked, there was no heartbeat.

I will come home straight away, I tell her, the desperate realisation suddenly surging through me that I am not in the place I am supposed to be. The consequences and reality of the sacrifice of playing cricket, for the first time, are shot through my system. I am on the other side of the world, helplessly far away. She is new to Manchester and doesn't know anyone very well yet. We agree that her friend, Alex, whom she models with and is nearby with her family, should know. She should call her and see if she can come round. Alex does so immediately and, when they work out the details of what's next, Daniella is told she needs to go to hospital to have a D&C procedure immediately.

I want to come back, I tell her. I'll come back now. She is insistent that I don't, that I play the last game, that I carry on. Her history – her need for me to pursue what I need to do in a way that her brother couldn't – pushes itself again to the front of the list, her absolute commitment that I should